	MANAGEMENT OF CONFIDENTIAL INFORMATION	
	Document no: ASMF4.3.	
Compiled by:	**Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager**	
Approved by:	**Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager**	

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1. Purpose

To ensure all confidential information obtained or generated during the production of Reference Materials (RMs) is protected and handled in accordance with ISO 17034:2016 Clause 4.3.

2. Scope

Applies to all personnel, subcontractors, and external parties involved in RM production, including handling of customer data, proprietary methods, and internal technical records.

3. Definitions

- **Confidential Information**: Any non-public data, documents, or communications received from clients or generated internally that must be protected from unauthorized disclosure.
- **Authorized Disclosure**: Release of confidential information permitted by law or contractual agreement.

4. Responsibilities

- **Top Management**: Ensures implementation and enforcement of confidentiality policies.
- **Laboratory Manager**: Maintains records and monitors compliance.
- **All Personnel**: Adhere to confidentiality agreements and report breaches

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5. Procedure steps

5.1. Identification of confidential information

- Classify all incoming and internal data as confidential, restricted, or public. This includes customer specifications, propriety methods, RM characterisation data, and subcontractor reports.

5.2. Access control

- Limit access to confidential information to authorised personnel only.
- Maintain access logs and permissions within the document control system.

5.3. Confidentiality agreements

- All staff, subcontractors, and visitors must sign a confidentiality agreement.
- Agreements will be reviewed annually or upon a role change.

5.4. Handling and storage

- All physical documents to be locked in cabinets, digital files in encrypted systems.

5.5. Disclosure Protocol

In the event where disclosure is required law or by contract agreement:

- Notify all individuals concerned before disclosure, unless prohibited by law.
- Record the nature, reason, and recipient of the disclosure.

6. Record Maintenance

- Signed confidentiality agreement ie. Non-disclosure agreement
- Access logs
- Breach investigation reports
- Training records
- Disclosure records

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7. Training

- Conduct annual training on confidentiality policies and ISO 17034 and ISO 17043 requirements

Examples of confidentiality breaches:

Scenario	Description	Impact
Unattended Documents	A technician leaves printed RM characterization data on a shared desk overnight	Risk of unauthorized access or data leakage
Email Misfire	A staff member accidentally sends a customer's proprietary method to the wrong client	Breach of contract and potential legal liability
Unauthorised sharing	A subcontractor discusses RM composition with a third party not bound by NDA.	Violation of ISO 17034 and ISO 17043 as well as reputational damage
Public disclosure	Staff mention client-specific RM details during a conference presentation.	Breach of trust and confidentiality

8. Review and Audit

- Procedure reviewed annually during management review
- Internal audits to verify compliance and effectiveness

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9. Revisions

Revision no	Content changed	Reason for revision

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